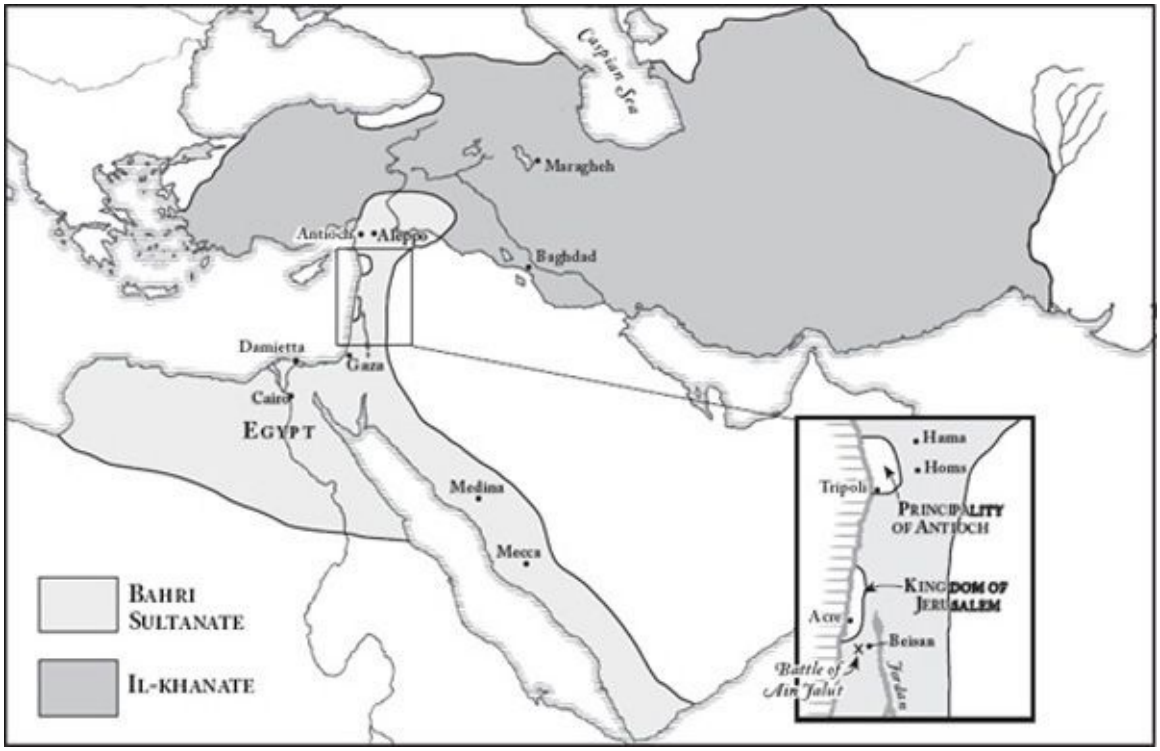
under Berke's control) to Egypt every year; the slave regiments, continually replenished, remained the strongest instrument of Baibars's power.[14]

In 1261, Baibars lassoed the role of Commander of the Faithful by welcoming an Abbasid refugee, fleeing the Mongol-occupied city of Baghdad, into Cairo, and declaring him the new Abbasid caliph, under Bahri protection. Hulagu had destroyed the ancient heart of Islam; now Baibars was posing as its restorer. The "heathen Tartars," wrote the fourteenth-century Arab historian Ibn Khaldun, "abolished the seat of the Caliphate and . . . made unbelief prevail in place of belief," but Baibars had snatched the fading torch:

> [I]t was God's benevolence that He rescued the faith by reviving its dying breath and restoring the unity of the Muslims in the Egyptian realms. . . . He did this by sending to the Muslims, from this Turkish nation and from among its great and numerous tribes, rulers to defend them and utterly loyal helpers, who were brought from the House of War to the House of Islam under the rule of slavery. . . . [S]ome of them are chosen to sit on the throne of the Sultans and direct the affairs of the Muslims, in accordance with divine providence and with the mercy of God.[15]



50.1 The Bahri Sultanate

A pleasant side effect of this decision was the immediate allegiance of the *sharif* of Mecca, the most powerful tribal chief in the Holy City, with the